

Editor's Preface

In early 2008, a friend visited me at my home in Birmingham, UK. He was visibly emotional and asked if I could give him a translation of the Qur'ān in English. He explained that he had a non-Muslim work colleague who had been enthralled by the Qur'ān and that he, as a Muslim, felt ashamed he had not read it. So I gave him a spare translation I had and began to tell him some basic facts he should know as a seeker of truth –

The Qur'ān is a unique book for a multitude of reasons. To name a few:

- It does not read in chronological order of revelation –
 - i.e. the first verse you read from *Sūrah* 1 was not the first verse revealed
 - nor the last verse from *Sūrah* 114 the very last verse revealed of the Qur'ān.
- The Qur'ān was revealed over a period of 23 years to the Prophet Muhammad –
 - Sometimes a few *ayats* at a time – (the first revelation began with five *ayat*, then seven, etc.) and at other times, *Sūrahs* (chapters) were revealed as a whole.

(An *Ayat* is normally translated as 'a verse' - a more accurate linguistic translation would be 'Sign' [of God])

- The Archangel Gabriel, under instruction from God, informed the Prophet to arrange the various *ayats* into *Sūrahs*.
- These *Sūrahs* (chapters) can be divided into two types –
 - those revealed before the migration of the Muslim community – The Makkan Period
 - and those revealed after the migration – The Madīnan period.
 - These *Sūrahs* would often include *Ayats* from both time periods
- The significance of the two periods –
 - in **Makkah** the call to one God was new. The Believers were opposed, beaten and oppressed by the Makkans who were the main proponents of idol-worship in Arabia. The revelations in Makkah were regarding Monotheism, Paradise and Hellfire, the Day of Judgment etc. This was a period of many trials and tribulations for the Prophet Muhammad and the Believers.
 - in **Madīnah** the Prophet was the leader of the Islāmic state. The revelations here centred on establishing the religion, engaging the enemies of God, social and legal rulings on marriage, divorce, inheritance, punishment, etc.
 - The challenges of both periods were different and the various *Ayats* reflect this.

After explaining the importance of knowing the biography of the Prophet in order to deepen one's understanding of the Qur'ān, I began explaining how amazingly, the Qur'ān has been preserved word for word in written and oral form for over fourteen hundred years – a feat unmatched by any other book, including the Old and New Testament. I then went on to mention the many scientific miracles contained in the Qur'ān and also the prophecies in the Bible about the Prophet Muhammad.

All this information I was relaying to my friend was scattered over many books and not contained in a single publication that I could give him. It was at this stage it became evident to me that there was a need to publish a translation of the Qur'ān which would give its reader a complete and informed introduction to the miraculous book, and so, **The Qur'ān Project** was born.

The Translation

Of all published works, the Qur'ān is perhaps the least translatable. Arabic is not at all easy to translate into a language so widely and radically differing from it in structure and genius as English, unless it be with the aid of loose periphrasis and lax paraphrase.

Even so the fire of the original is quenched, its vivacious perspicuity is lost, and the so-called literal translation looks rugged and dreary. That the language of the Arabs abounds in nuances and both the noun and the verb are extremely flexible, is a fact well known to every student of that tongue. The difficulty is increased hundredfold when one has to render into English, with any degree of accuracy and precision, a work so rich in meaning, so pithy in expression, so vigorous in style and so subtle in implications as the Qur'ān. To reproduce even partially its exotic beauty, wonderful grandeur and magical vivacity without sacrificing the requirements of the English idiom and usage, is the despair of the translator and an ideal impossible of attainment. The result is that every fresh attempt at translating the Holy Writ brings home, in varying degrees, the truth of the old saying that nothing is so unlike an original as its copy.

Nevertheless, as difficult a task as it was, over twenty-three translations of the Qur'ān were consulted in an attempt to render the words of the Qur'ān into the English language and the result is, God-willing, a translation read easily by most. The reader should take note that there exists a number of other translations of the Qur'ān which are more eloquent and richer in language and whilst the current translation may be suitable for some, it may not be ideal for others.

Sūrah Introductions and Appendices

It was decided to add M. Mawdudi's Sūrah introductions from his commentary of the Qur'ān, 'Towards Understanding the Qur'ān' (available online – www.quranproject.org). These have been edited and abridged to include the most relevant information for a beginner. The following chapters were then also selected to be included:

- Short Biography of the Prophet Muhammad
- Introduction to the Study of the Qur'ān
- The Unique Qur'ānic Generation
- Preservation and Literary Challenge of the Qur'ān
- Scientific Miracles of the Qur'ān

- Miracles Performed
- Old and New Testament Prophecies of Muhammad
- Women in Islām
- How do I become a Muslim?
- Quick Guide to Ablution and Prayer
- Frequently Asked Questions about Islām - Short Answers –

The Qur’ān Project Website

The website www.quranproject.org was setup to accompany the publication. Here readers would be able to read it all online, download it, order their free copy, and go through the many additional sections including free online library, audio and video etc.

Final Note

Many of those involved have been completely humbled by the opportunity given to them by God to partake in this project. All praise and thanks are for Him and Him alone, the Lord of the Worlds. Often God uses diverse and numerous people for His work and this endeavour has been no different. So many people have offered their time, help and services to this project and are too many to mention here. God knows every single one of them and we ask Him to accept this deed from us and make it as a means of achieving His love, mercy and ultimately Paradise – (ameen).

All that is good and correct in this publication, and anyone who is subsequently guided by it, this is from God and a mercy from Him. Any mistakes and errors are from ourselves and we ask the forgiveness of God for them.

‘O God, Creator of the heavens and the earth, accept this deed from us and forgive us for any shortcomings. Enter us and our families into the highest levels of Paradise and protect us from being touched by the Fire even for a moment. Our prayers, sacrifices, lives and death are all for You. Bless us with Your love, the love of whom You love and the love of deeds which bring us closer to Your love. O God, have mercy on us through the Qur’ān and make it for us a Light, Mercy and Guidance. Make the last part of our lives its best, the last deed the best one, and the best day of our lives the Day we meet You.’ [ameen]

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